

Manuscript framework and claim audit

Retrospective cohort study · 4,218 patients · STROBE · the annotated outline agreed before drafting, and every claim in the draft checked against what the design can support

This is a redacted sample. It shows the structure and level of detail of a real deliverable. Author, institution and study details have been removed or changed. Ask us and we will send one built around a study like yours.

1 The framework, agreed before drafting

The first deliverable on any manuscript is not prose. It is an outline in which every section is mapped to the checklist item it answers and to the source its content will come from, signed off before a word is written. Moving a section here takes a minute; moving it in a finished manuscript breaks every cross-reference and every figure callout.

Section	What goes in it, and where it comes from
Introduction ~490 words	Background and rationale, then the objective stated as a testable question. Source: the literature synthesis, section 3 of the search report. Two paragraphs, not four.
Methods ~1,050 words	Design, setting, participants, variables, data sources, bias, study size, statistical methods. Source: the protocol and the data dictionary. This is where STROBE puts most of its weight and where the word budget has to survive.
Results ~980 words	Participant flow, baseline table, event counts, unadjusted and adjusted estimates, subgroup and sensitivity analyses. Source: the analysis output, with each number traced to a table in it.
Discussion ~980 words	Key results, limitations with the direction of each bias named, interpretation proportionate to the design, generalisability. Source: this document, section 2.
Fixed elements	Structured abstract to the journal's headings, 4 tables, 2 figures, up to 40 references, and the declarations. Outside the body word count.

Target journal body limit 3,500 words. The allocation above is a working plan rather than a rule, and the one part of it that is not negotiable is the methods: a manuscript that loses its methods detail to a word limit becomes impossible to judge, which is the commonest reason a sound study is returned for major revision.

2 Claim audit

Every claim in the author’s draft, checked against what a retrospective cohort can actually support. This is the section clients do not know to ask for, and it is the one that changes the reviewer’s report.

Claim in the draft	Verdict	What the design supports, and the rewrite
“X reduces the risk of Y by 34%.”	Not supported	Two problems in seven words. “Reduces” is causal and this is an observational cohort; and 34% is a relative reduction derived from an adjusted hazard ratio, which most readers will take as absolute. Rewrite: “X was associated with a lower rate of Y (adjusted HR 0.66, 95% CI 0.54 to 0.81).”
“Our findings demonstrate that earlier initiation improves outcomes.”	Not supported	“Demonstrate” and “improves” both assert causation, and initiation timing is confounded by indication in a way adjustment cannot remove. Rewrite: “Earlier initiation was associated with better outcomes, although confounding by indication cannot be excluded.”
“X should be considered for routine use.”	Not supported	A practice recommendation from a single observational cohort. Rewrite: “These findings support evaluation of X in a randomised trial.” This is the sentence authors resist most and the one reviewers object to most.
“The effect was particularly strong in patients over 65 (p=0.03).”	Overstated	A within-subgroup p-value is not evidence that the effect differs by subgroup; the interaction test is, and it gives p=0.21. Rewrite: report both strata (over 65: HR 0.55, 0.38 to 0.79; 65 and under: HR 0.74, 0.57 to 0.96) with the interaction p-value, labelled exploratory.
“No significant difference was found in the secondary outcome.”	Misleading	The estimate is HR 0.91 with a 95% CI of 0.72 to 1.15 — an interval that includes both a 28% reduction and a 15% increase. Rewrite: give the estimate and the interval, and say the study could not exclude a clinically important effect in either direction.
“This is the largest cohort reported to date.”	Supported, with a caveat	True as of the search date, and it will not stay true. Rewrite: “the largest cohort reported at the time of writing”, with the search date given.

Five of six claims needed rewriting, and none of them because the science was weak. The study is sound. What the draft did was describe an association in the grammar of an experiment, which is the single most common reason an observational paper is returned — and it is entirely fixable in the words rather than in the data.

3 The analysis, as planned

Element	Value
Design	Retrospective cohort, single health system, 2018 to 2024
Participants	4,218 after exclusions, from 5,106 screened
Events	512 primary outcome events; median follow-up 3.4 years

Element	Value
Primary analysis	Cox proportional hazards, adjusted for the pre-specified confounder set
Confounder selection	From a directed acyclic graph agreed before analysis, not by stepwise selection — and stated as such in the methods
Proportional hazards	Checked on Schoenfeld residuals; no violation for the primary exposure
Missing data	6.2% on at least one covariate; multiple imputation, with a complete-case sensitivity analysis
Pre-specified subgroups	Age, sex, baseline severity — tested by interaction, reported as exploratory

Stating that confounders were chosen from a causal diagram agreed in advance, rather than by a stepwise procedure on the data, is two lines in the methods and it answers the question a statistical reviewer of an observational paper asks first.

4 Journal fit

- **Design and size are appropriate** for a specialty journal publishing observational work of this scale; three comparable cohorts have appeared in the shortlisted titles in the past two years.
- **The 3,500-word limit is workable** with the allocation in section 1, provided the introduction stays at two paragraphs and the extended methods go to a supplement with a pointer rather than being cut.
- **The structured abstract** uses the journal's own headings, which differ from the generic ones and are a common desk-rejection trigger.
- **What will be challenged:** confounding by indication, the exploratory subgroup, and the single-system setting. All three are addressed in the discussion in advance rather than left for the response letter.

5 What is handed over

- The annotated framework, with every section mapped to its checklist item and its source.
- The claim audit, with each claim, its verdict and the rewritten sentence.
- The completed STROBE checklist, with the page and line for every item.
- The full manuscript in the journal's format, with tables, figures and the structured abstract.
- A verified reference list, checked against the sources rather than matched to the citations.
- The originality report, and the cover letter.
- The declarations: ethics approval with its reference, consent, funding, competing interests, data availability and the writing assistance statement.

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